Desert terrain

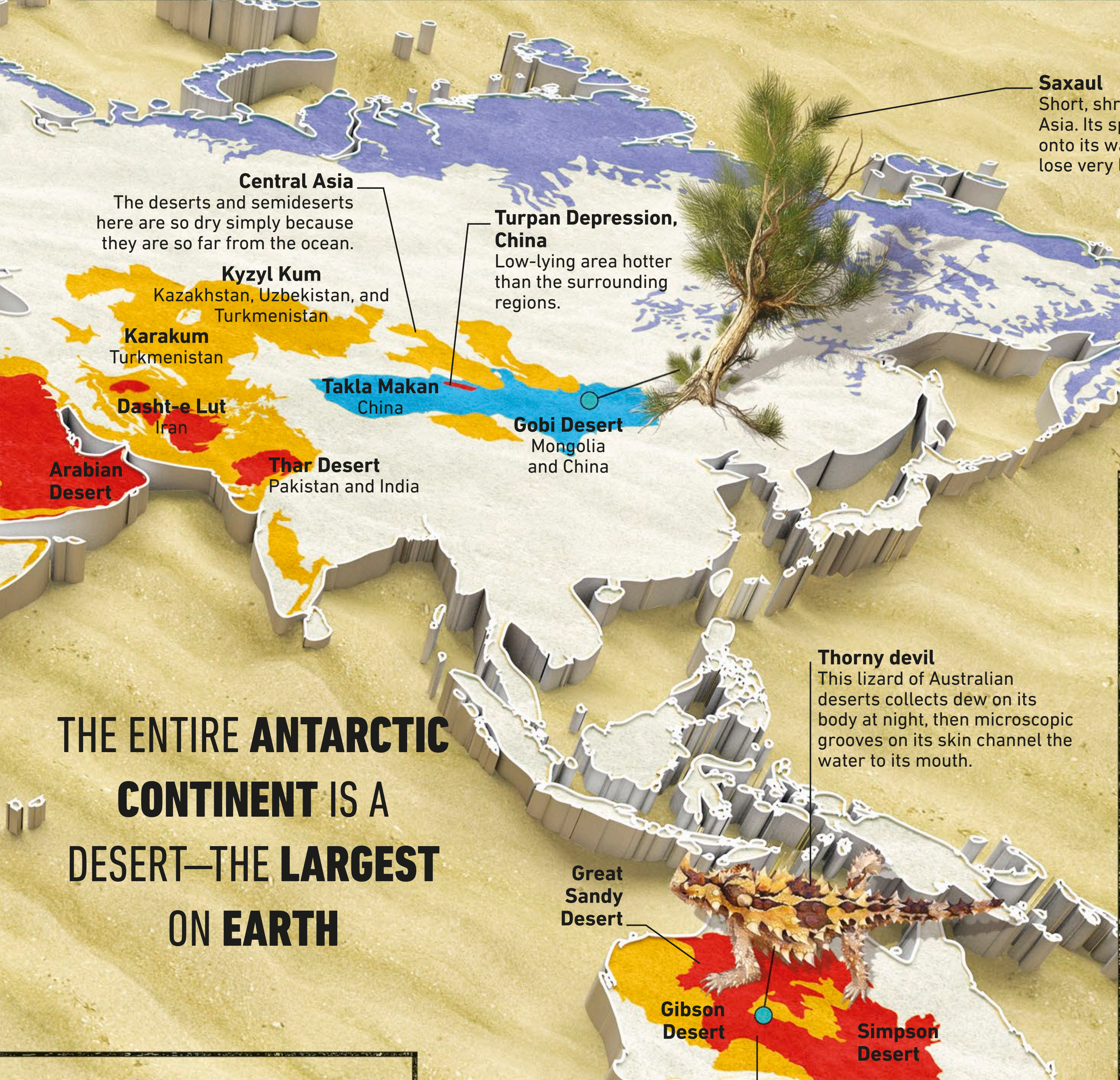
Deserts range widely in how they look. Soil forms very slowly and the land is often bare rock or gravel. Any loose, sandy soil may be blown into dunes. Sometimes, though, tough grasses or fleshy plants bind the soil together.

Dunes, or "sand seas"
Shifting mountains of sand can prevent plant growth.

Rock and gravel
Where no plants grow, the bedrock is often visible.

Dry grassland
Desert grasses can form soil and provide food for grazers.

Fleshy plants
Fleshy, water-storing plants may form thick vegetation.



TYPES OF DESERTS

Hot desert
Tends to lie in two bands, 15–35 degrees north and south of the equator, where the atmosphere tends to create weather systems that produce no rainfall.

Semidesert
This dry land type often lies at the edges of deserts and ranges from dry grassland to shrubland. Some have short periods of rain, but no more than 20 in (500 mm) a year.

Cold deserts
Includes the Gobi in Asia and the Atacama in South America. Freezing cold in some seasons but may be very hot at other times.

Tundra
Treeless region of low-growing shrubs. Qualifies as a desert due to rainfall of less than 10 in (250 mm) a year, but low evaporation means there is no lack of water.

Polar desert
Includes the driest, coldest parts of the Arctic where few tundra plants can live, and the ice sheets on Greenland and Antarctica, where almost nothing lives at all.

THE ENTIRE **ANTARCTIC CONTINENT** IS A DESERT—THE **LARGEST** ON **EARTH**

AND IS ABOUT THE SAME SIZE AS THE ENTIRE UNITED STATES!